

COUNT TO 15, THEN ANSWER ANY PRODUCT QUESTION

Design a Feature That Shows Who Unfollowed You

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1 Buy time, then count to 15

Tell the interviewer you're taking a moment, then breathe and count to 15 in your head. Do it even if you already know how you'd start. Use the count to decide what you'd ask first.

EXAMPLE

"Give me a few seconds to think this through."

When you hit 15, don't start designing. Ask your questions.

2 Ask clarifying questions

For a design question, ask three to five. Pick the ones that change your answer the most. "Shows who unfollowed you" could mean a live alert, a weekly list, or only a count. It also matters whether it's for everyone or only creators.

EXAMPLE

"Is this for everyone or only creators? A live alert or a summary? Should people know they'll show up when they unfollow?"

Repeat their answer back before you move on: "Got it, everyday users, a weekly summary, and the goal is fewer people leaving the app for shady unfollow-tracker apps."

3 Break it apart on paper

Write the question at the top of the page and split it into layers before you pick anything. Go from who, to what bugs them, to ideas. Don't pick a fix yet.

EXAMPLE

```
Unfollow feature for everyday users
├ Users: everyday posters, small creators, private accounts
  │
  │   └ Why they want to know: _____
    │
    │   └ Ideas for each one: _____
      │
      │   └ The one you pick: _____
        │
        │   └ How you'd measure it: _____
```

Fill in the blanks out loud. Turn the page toward the interviewer so they can follow along.

4 Work it top down

Go one layer at a time and say why at every step. Name the user, the pain point, three ideas, then pick one.

EXAMPLE

1. Start with everyday posters. Say they care most about friends, not strangers.
User: everyday posters
2. Say the pain point is seeing the count drop and not knowing who left.
Pain point: a drop with no answer
3. Three ideas: a live unfollow alert, a weekly list of who left, and a count with no names.
Ideas: live alert, weekly list, count only
4. Pick the weekly list, limited to people you follow back. It answers the question without starting a fight every time someone leaves.
Pick: weekly list of mutuals who left
5. Say how you'd measure it. If it works, people stop checking their follower count over and over.
Metric: follower-count checks per person per day

If they push back on your user or pain point, take theirs and keep going.

5 Check it with the interviewer

You can't run user research in the room, so the interviewer is your user. Say your pick and ask if it's the direction they want. They'll agree, push on a corner case, or point you somewhere else. Answer the corner case, then give a rough cost and time to build.

EXAMPLE

You: "I'd show a weekly list of people you follow who stopped following you. Does that direction work?"

Interviewer: "What about the privacy of the person who unfollowed?"

You: "We'd tell everyone up front that mutuals see a weekly list, and blocked or removed accounts never show up. Another corner case: someone unfollows by accident and follows again, so we only list people still gone at the end of the week. It's one weekly screen using data we already have, so a small team could test it in about 8 weeks."

Interviewer: "Fair."

If they point you somewhere else, don't defend your first pick. Go back to your tree, take the next idea, and run it through the same checks.

Practice on this one

Set a 10-minute timer, have a friend play the interviewer, and record it. Run all five steps out loud, count included. Play it back and flag anything you decided without saying why.

☐ Should Instagram hide follower counts?

Score every answer

Use this checklist after each practice run:

- ☐ Did I say "give me a few seconds" and count to 15?
- ☐ Did I ask three to five clarifying questions and repeat the goal back?
- ☐ Did I sketch users, pain points and ideas on paper before picking?
- ☐ Did I pick one idea and say why?
- ☐ Did I handle the interviewer's corner case and give a rough cost and time?
- ☐ Did I say how I'd measure it?